# Application Project Proposal: Schedule Build Coding Tutorial

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## Context and Learners

Each term, department scheduling coordinators at UNC Charlotte submit course section information to the Office of the Registrar so it can be built into Banner for the upcoming schedule. Most coordinators are administrative staff, not Banner specialists, and scheduling is only one part of their job. Because the schedule build happens only a few times a year, many coordinators forget the details between cycles and relearn the process under deadline pressure. The same errors come up every term, especially with distance education coding (instructional method and campus codes) and cross-listed sections. These errors create rework for the Registrar's Office and can cause sections to display incorrectly to students or be assessed the wrong fees.

A typical learner is someone like Dana, an administrative support associate who has worked in her department for several years. She is comfortable with spreadsheets and email but only uses the scheduling template a few times a year. She schedules over 100 sections per term, often while handling other deadlines, and she wants a quick way to get it right without calling the Registrar's Office for every question.

To meet this need, I plan to develop a short interactive tutorial (about 15 minutes) in Articulate 360. The tutorial will walk learners through the coding decisions for distance education and cross-listed sections using the actual template, include practice scenarios with feedback, and end with a scored assessment. Because it is self-paced, coordinators can revisit it right before each schedule build.

## Objective

Given a scheduling request for a distance education or cross-listed section and the Registrar's course template (Condition), department scheduling coordinators (Audience) will complete the section's instructional method, campus, and cross-list fields (Behavior) with no coding errors on at least 4 of 5 practice sections (Degree).

Bloom's category: Apply. Learners are carrying out a known procedure in a new situation, deciding which codes fit each section and entering them correctly.

## Learning Theory

I plan to use cognitivism, specifically cognitive load theory. Cognitivism focuses on how learners organize, store, and retrieve information, which fits a task where coordinators must remember a set of related rules and apply them months after their last use (Ertmer & Newby, 1993). Cognitive load theory adds that working memory is limited, so learning suffers when too many new elements are presented at once (Sweller, 1988). Coding a distance education or cross-listed section involves several interacting fields, so presenting everything at once would likely overwhelm a learner like Dana.

Based on this theory, the tutorial will break the task into smaller chunks, use worked examples before independent practice, and show the real template instead of abstract explanations to reduce extraneous load (Clark et al., 2006; Sweller et al., 1998). I did not choose behaviorism because the task is not just memorizing codes. Coordinators have to decide which rule applies to each section, which calls for understanding and not only repetition.

## Instructional Design Model

I will use the Successive Approximation Model, or SAM (Allen & Sites, 2012). SAM works well for a small project with a clear audience and a subject matter expert who is available for quick feedback. Its phases will guide this project as follows:

1. **Preparation:** Gather background on the most common template errors and hold a short Savvy Start session with a Registrar's Office staff member to confirm priorities and review rough ideas.
2. **Iterative Design:** Sketch a few quick prototypes of the practice scenarios and review them with the subject matter expert, revising until the scenarios match real situations.

3. **Iterative Development:** Build an alpha version in Articulate 360, test it with one or two coordinators, revise into a beta, and then finalize the gold version for submission.

The repeated small cycles let me catch problems early, which is especially useful since the scenarios have to reflect real coding rules accurately.

## References

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